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THE SILENT BACKSLIDE

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LETTER FROM THE EDITORS

Dear Readers,

Welcome to our second print edition of the year! We are so excited to share it with you. This issue has been one of our favorites to edit and features articles on a breadth of topics—from the nutrients we put into our bodies to press suppression in Hungary and the politics of open source AI. There is something for every reader in The Politic's final issue of 2024.

In our first piece, "Udder Alternatives," Natalia Armas Perez explores the alternative milk scene, bringing together the voices of dairy farmers and plant-based milk manufacturers alike. In "The Delivery Revolution," Emi Glass investigates the home birth movement, prompting readers to consider the merits and potential risks of removing birth from the hospital setting. In our cover piece, "The Silent Backslide," Ben Szovati Coulter writes about the suppression of the free press in Prime Minister Viktor Orbán's Hungary. He examines both the culture of media repression in the country and the resilience of journalists who defy the government in their quest for truth.

Bringing us closer to home, Kiran Yeh examines the landscape of abortion discourse at Yale in "Abort or Engage." Then, in "Unfair Use," Aubrie Williams dissects the legal and personal struggle for artistic ownership in the age of open source AI, when models like Stable Diffusion can near-perfectly mimic artists' style. Our interview piece this cycle is with the journalist and World Fellow Roba El Husseini. Conducted by our Multimedia Managing Editor, Eliza Daunt, the interview focuses on forgotten stories from the Middle East's front lines, centering the experiences of children in the al-Hol camp in Syria.

We extend our gratitude to the writers, editors, and designers who helped bring this issue to life. We hope you enjoy reading as much as we enjoyed putting everything together.

With Love,
The Politic Managing Board

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UDDER

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A MILK MOO-VEMENT

BY NATALIA ARMAS PEREZ

A handwritten chalkboard listing daily offerings and local favorites hangs next to the display counter at Scratch Baking, a small bakery in Milford, Connecticut. Lines often flow out the door as new faces and regulars stop by for their morning drink of choice and a pastry. During peak business hours, Bridget Cassidy, Scratch Baking's assistant manager, can be found frothing milk and pouring espresso shots while manning the front counter. More often than not, a once rare, now quotidian question pops up: Can I get that with oat milk?

With the rise of non-dairy beverages and plant-based milk products in recent years, coffee shops and bakeries have witnessed a shift in consumer preferences. "Alternative milk requests have become a norm, enough so that we tell our baristas to clarify what customers want if they don't specify. We only carry oat and almond milk, but there are so many milk substitutes out there," Cassidy told The Politic.

The plant-based milk industry has grown from humble beginnings in the early 1990s. Soy milk served as the top alternative drink until Blue Diamond Almond Milk debuted on supermarket shelves in 2008. Toppling soy milk as consumers' milk substitute of choice, almond milk emerged as a dominant force in the industry, comprising 63% of the total market in 2020. Only recently has a new challenger, oat milk, made waves in the refrigerated aisle. Since 2016, oat milk edged its way to second place behind the market leader. Be it Chobani, Oatly, or Nesquik, oat-based products have become an industry staple. So much so that Almond-Breeze launched an almond-oat blend in March of 2024, combining the market's two powerhouses.

Despite almond and oat milk's current dominance, the alternative dairy industry is ever-evolving. Companies are constantly rolling out new substitutes and derivatives to keep up with the growing market, whether it be derived from peas, hemp seeds, or cashews. Brands like Lattini and Bam have found success with sunflower and buckwheat

TERNATIVES

milk, while walnut and pecan milk are starting to break ground with consumers. Even past favorites are resurging. "Until recently, customers would ask for soy once in a blue moon. Just this past week, I've had four or five people order a soy latte, which I thought was strange," said Cassidy. Even textbook definitions reflect consumer shifts as Merriam-Webster's entry for milk newly includes those "produced from seeds or fruit that resembles and is used similarly to cow's milk."

Cultural trends play a large role in consumer decision-making, especially with coffee orders. Evan Cassidy, front-of-house manager of Scratch and Bridget Cassidy's husband, noted, "We see upticks whenever a new health fad or news headline comes out. I remember when keto was all the rage and people wanted heavy cream in their drinks. It sounds odd, but it was popular enough that we kept it in our front refrigerator because of high demand." In the plant-based context, "about four or five years ago, we saw oat and almond milk really skyrocket in popularity. Everyone wanted it and kept asking for it. As a coffee shop, we keep up with trends to provide for our customers," he said.

But not everyone is happy with the new milk fads. Farm bureaus, rural folk, and even Congress members worry that flashy new alternatives are stealing customers from traditional dairy providers. In 2023, Senators Tammy Baldwin (D-WI), Jim Risch (R-ID), Susan Collins (R-ME), and Peter Welch (D-VT) introduced the bipartisan DAIRY PRIDE Act (HR 1462), a bill that would bar brands from labeling their dairy alternatives as "milk." Companies would have to drop the title unless their product came from a hooved animal or utilized animal milk at some point in its production process.

To safeguard dairy farmers' livelihood, the bill focused on redefining branding standards for milk alternatives. Proponents believe that by formalizing dairy-related terminology, they might distinguish "imitations" from the original. In a December 2023 press release, Senator Collins summarized the crux of the issue: "I know how hard Maine's dairy farmers work to produce nutritious milk, yogurt, cheese, and other products. It is unfair for other industries to capitalize on milk's nutritious brand."

Milk was once an everyday staple. Now, its role in daily life has dwindled. Americans are drifting away from a cold glass every morning and its milk-mustache charm. According to the International Food Information Council, in the U.S., Generation Z alone reduced its milk consumption by 36% in 2024.

A possible explanation lies in a wave of health and environmental worries about the sustainability of dairy farming. In 2022, 77% of plant-

About four or five years ago, we saw oat and almond milk really skyrocket in popularity. Everyone wanted it and kept asking for it. As a coffee shop, we keep up with trends to provide for our customers.

Our food system is taking a huge toll on the planet, and some of the foods we love most have the biggest carbon footprints. We believe most people want to do something about this, but simply don't know what to do. Switching to alternative dairy is one small lifestyle change people can make that can positively impact the environment.

based milk consumers were driven to switch because of environmental well-being, according to the Journal of Dairy Science. Generally, members of Generation Z are willing to pay higher prices for more sustainable products and adjust their budgets accordingly.

The ecological impacts of everyday transactions influence consumers when they weigh options in the refrigerated aisle. In particular, concerns surrounding the dairy industry's land use, greenhouse gas emissions, and water contamination have sprung up. In 2018, Our World in Data found that a liter of dairy milk had a carbon footprint of 3.15 kg, while almond milk paled at 0.7 kg. Similarly, dairy milk's land use and freshwater consumption steamrolled that of soy, rice, and oat milk.

Bella Willeboordse, brand manager of Bored Cow, a bioidentical milk alternative produced by Tomorrow Farms, commented on environmentally-conscious consumerism. "Our food system is taking a huge toll on the planet, and some of the foods we love most have the biggest carbon footprints. We believe most people want to do something about this, but simply don't know what to do. Switching to alternative dairy is one small lifestyle change people can make that can positively impact the environment," she said.

Bored Cow uses DNA sequences to ferment whey protein, a protein derived from cow milk. Without any animal input, their products retain the nutrients of traditional dairy milk without the lactose or cholesterol. According to studies conducted by the carbon assessment platform PlanetFWD, Bored Cow's process requires 96% less land and generates 44% lower emissions than traditional dairy farms. Willeboordse said the "first step to reducing our global climate footprint is to understand what is having the biggest impact, and why that is."

Kiki Milk, a plant-based milk start-up inspired by child allergy concerns, is also taking strides to improve environmental sustainability. "Every company has a carbon footprint, so it's really about striving to minimize your contribution. We support regenerative farms whenever we can, and opt for packaging that is shelf-stable and recyclable. Kiki Milk works with EcoCart, a company that helps offset carbon emissions from online purchases. We're just working to do the best we can," said Rebecca Zimmerman, Director of Communications for Kiki Milk.

Plant-based milks take pride in their environmental friendliness. However, certain plant products do take a toll on the Earth's resources. California, often hailed as the "breadbasket" and "salad bowl" of the U.S., supplies a vital share of the nation's fresh produce and grains, including 99% of United States almonds. Almond groves are concentrated in the arid Central Valley, which faces frequent droughts. A singular almond consumes over a gallon of water. A glass of almond milk requires over 16.25 gallons.

Nonetheless, market demand for milk alternatives feeds the growth of the plant-based industry. In light of these trends, the American dairy sector is reckoning with a volatile consumer base and deteriorating perception of cow milk.

In the eyes of the average dairy farmer, supermarket aisles filled with hemp and pea milk are merely a symptom of a larger development in American culture. "The American population is experiencing a drastic separation from its food supply. We've moved from local farmsteads and backyard operations to hyper-efficient corporate entities. Human beings are removed from the soil, the animals, and the processes that provide the nutrients enjoyed. So, it's easy to walk into a grocery store, pick up a milk carton, and not think about the work that went into that singular unit," said Michael Benedetti, Senior Director of Quality, Regulation, and Sustainability at Clover Sonoma, a dairy manufacturer based in Northern California. Benedetti connects these concerns to the surge in alternative milks.

Dairy farms in Sonoma County, Clover's home base, are under pressure by efforts fueled by environmental and ethical concerns. In the 2024 election season, Measure J, a controversial ban on large animal farms, directly targeted dairy cooperatives like Clover Sonoma. More specifically, Measure J aimed to ban medium and large Concentrated Animal Feeding Operations (CAFOs). Most dairy operations in Sonoma County fit the bill of a CAFO, which is defined as facilities where animals are kept in confinement for at least 45 days over a full calendar year and meet or exceed specific size thresholds.

Given California's leading role in the dairy industry, passing Measure J would have had a major impact. Opponents of the bill, including local farmers, argue that multi-generational family farms would have to shut down operations based on Measure J's outlined criteria for closure. "It doesn't matter how big your farm is or how many cows you own. We all rely on each other, and we knew that something like Measure J would cause a ripple effect. The local veterinarian who takes care of the cows will have fewer customers, and the feed mill will probably have to raise

prices to stay open. Our production would have taken a 40% hit, give or take," said Benedetti.

Mainly concerned with ethical animal treatment, Measure J's provisions were based on large numbers and leave little room for consideration of individual cases. "It doesn't account for the efforts or pursuits undertaken by local dairy farms. You can be over their perceived limit but practice organic and sustainable measures. When you're going off the numbers, you don't get the bigger picture," said Benedetti.

But dairy farmers didn't have to hold their breath for long. Early numbers indicated a landslide defeat as 85% of voters rejected Measure J. But despite this win, the average farmer continues to confront milk's increasingly poor public perception.

In response to environmental concerns, dairy farms take the helm to address their role in the larger agricultural ecosystem. Efforts to reduce greenhouse gas emissions and water contamination from milk production align with programs that educate farmers on nurturing a more sustainable tomorrow.

Kirsten Workman, a Nutrient Management and Environmental Sustainability Specialist at Cornell University, works with farmers in the Finger Lakes region of New York to achieve such goals. "There are a lot of opportunities for increased sustainability for dairy farms, especially with integrated farming where we can analyze the carbon footprint of the crops fed to the cows and the manure used for fertilization. Keeping those resources very circular and in a local loop presents exciting pathways for improvement," she said.

As a senior extension associate for ProDAIRY, a New York state initiative focused on supporting dairy businesses, Workman plays a key role in the Dairy Net Zero Initiative.

Officially known as the Dairy Soil, Water, and Regeneration Project, this national effort is funded by the Foundation for Food and Agriculture Research and the Dairy Research Innovation Center, in collaboration with the Soil Health Institute. Eight universities and research locations across major U.S. dairy-producing areas are collaborating to study greenhouse gas emissions from dairy farm fields like nitrous oxide, methane, and carbon dioxide. Via data collection, researchers aim to refine greenhouse gas models and provide farmers with insights on how to improve both soil health and water quality.

"Tackling the problem from different angles and taking a step back to analyze the whole system is key. We're going back to square one by understanding cattle nutrition's impact on emissions or decreasing fertilizer imports. It's super high-tech and exciting when it comes to these kinds of projects," Workman said.

Dairy farmers can track carbon emissions from manure and craft plans moving forward with satellite imagery and sensors. Technological advancements allow the expansion of monitoring, enough so that lasers and light imagery have the potential to assess entire fields. Data collection only facilitates greater innovation to meet the needs of farmers, their cattle, and the environment. "It's all about strengthening that toolbox," said Workman.

In Clover Sonoma's case, local farmers share different seeds, grasses, and planting styles to promote regenerative agriculture. Whether through new plowing methods or manure applications to provide better yields, Sonoma County's dairy scene is leveraging collaboration to strengthen its impact. "Working with your neighbor is really powerful, we're becoming better farmers because of it," said Benedetti.

With continued collaboration, technology, and transparency, the dairy sector is poised to meet its goals while showing consumers the commitment to environmental consciousness behind every glass of milk.

"Every morning on my way to work, I pass six or seven dairies with cows grazing on the pasture. It's a powerful reminder of how we nourish the masses and how our treatment of the land and animals matters. If we want to continue providing, we need to work hard and care about our mission, which comes down to respecting the environment," said Benedetti.

Though milk's role in American culture has changed, it has not vanished. "Milk is nostalgic. It's something people grew up with, and that connection to childhood is still really strong. When people want a glass of milk, they want to feel good about it and enjoy it, no matter if it's plant or dairy-based," said Zimmerman.

The market has grown to accommodate new consumer preferences, with an abundance of choice. It might be easy to argue that conventional milk's pedestal is teetering, but the 'milk '-based branding of dairy alternatives proves that milk's nostalgic appeal will endure. The definition has certainly evolved—but in America's kitchens, milk is here to stay.

THE DELIVERY REVOLUTION: THE RISE OF HOME BIRTHS IN THE U.S.

BY EMI GLASS

"I wish somebody would have explained to me that there were different options before this happened to me. *Sometimes* that can save somebody from experiencing that same trauma."

Samantha Jordan, a doula and birth photographer based in Northeastern Ohio, wishes she had been better informed about her options as she approached her first childbirth. After two largely negative experiences with hospital birth, Jordan chose home birth when she was pregnant with her third child. She resolved to take control of her own experience. Jordan is one of an increasing number of American women who made the choice to labor at home rather than in the hospital.

Since the mid-20th century, the hospital has been culturally accepted in the United States as the safest place for a pregnant individual to give birth. But an increasing percentage of American women are choosing to give birth outside of the hospital. Between 2019 and 2020, there was a 22% increase in home births. Another 12% increase occurred between 2020 and 2021. While home births still account for a relatively small percentage of total births in the United States—about 1.51%—the trend continues to rise.

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Jaimi Sauder, a 30 year-old stay at home mom, feared that if she gave birth in a hospital, her doctors would not listen to her preferences. Sauder knew exactly how she wanted her delivery experience to look. She was certain she wanted to have a natural birth free of pain-killing interventions like an epidural—and she was adamantly opposed to a Cesarean section.

While Sauder knew she had a right to refuse certain treatments and procedures, she feared doctors might overzealously engage in medically unnecessary interventions. "I'm not very confrontational. So, if I'm in labor, I can't really advocate for myself. And my husband is not very confrontational either…that's what led me to looking at other options," Sauder said.

There is some evidence to support this worry. The hospital's biomedical approach to childbirth can encourage medical intervention that may not occur in other settings. Professor Rebecca Tannenbaum, a senior lecturer in History at Yale who specializes in the history of women's health, said, "[In the hospital] there are things like continuous fetal monitoring. A midwife might listen with the fetoscope once every couple of hours. [In the hospital], if there's

"[Doctors] are taught to intervene, and they just expect most women to do what they tell them to. When [a woman] questions something, or they want to try something different, [doctors] are taken aback by that, and they're like 'Well, I'm the doctor.' "

"When I decided to have a home birth, I knew that I wasn't going to have people in my space telling me that I can't when I know that I could. I was left to just labor in my own house, alone, as exactly how I needed. [My] labor was pretty intense, but it still was nothing compared to what I experienced at the hospital."

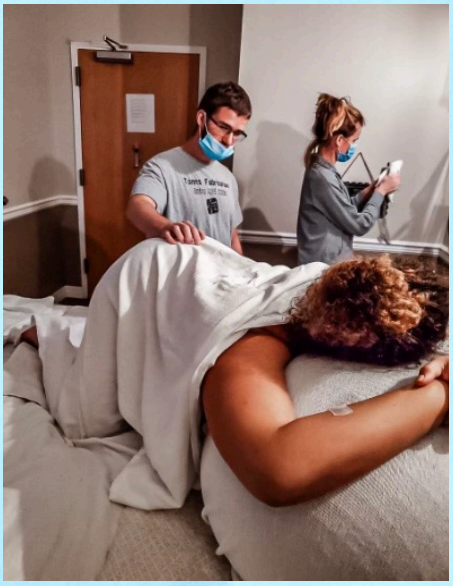
a small change, that might lead to some other intervention, which leads to another intervention, which leads to a cesarean."

Sauder worried that under the duress and pain of labor, she would not be able to properly defend her choice to have an unmedicated, natural birth.

Jordan echoed Sauder's claims about excessive medical interventions in hospitals. "All these interventions happen in a hospital. You get the Pitocin, the baby has a bad reaction to it. You get the epidural, the baby has a bad reaction to it. Now, your baby's in distress and you need to have an emergency C-section," Jordan said.

It is true that many women report negative experiences with hospital births. In 2023, the CDC analyzed a survey of 2,400 new mothers' experiences with hospital childbirth. The survey included frequent accounts of mistreatment, such as ignored requests for help, being shouted at, threats to withhold treatment, and pressure to accept unwanted treatment.

These reports are a symptom of a larger conversation within the birth care community. Evidence does demonstrate that maternity care in the US is intervention-heavy. In other words, women giving birth may experience a range of interventions that are not medically necessary. For example, the majority of women giving birth in the U.S. experience electronic fetal monitoring, receive intravenous fluids, and face restrictions on eating and drinking during labor. All of these interventions are considered medically unnecessary for most low-risk pregnancies.



Jaimi Sauder's first birth at a birthing center.

A substantial number of women also received more physically invasive interventions during their births, with 67% of women receiving epidurals, 31% receiving Pitocin to speed up delivery, 20% having their membranes artificially ruptured, and 31% undergoing cesarean sections. In other parts of the world, these numbers are lower. For example, in the Netherlands, which has a nationalized home birth program, the rate of Cesarean sections is under 17%. Notably, the U.S. also has the highest rate of both maternal and infant mortality rates compared to other high-income countries.

There is a legitimate concern amongst expectant mothers about being subjected to unnecessary medical interventions. Sauder pointed out that there is an inherent power dynamic between the physician and a laboring mother, which makes women vulnerable to interventions they may not want nor need. "[Doctors] are taught to intervene, and they just expect most women to do what they tell them to. When [a woman] questions something, or they want to try something different, [doctors] are taken aback by that, and they're like 'Well, I'm the doctor,'" Sauder said.

But this sentiment, while common in the natural birth community, is certainly not unanimous. Carol Glass, a registered nurse who worked in the Emergency Department for over 30 years, expressed more faith in doctors' ability to respect the wishes of mothers pursuing natural childbirths. "Nowadays, patients have to give consent for anything that's done [to them]. Hospitals are aware that women are wanting to have a natural birth, so they will try to accommodate them," Glass said.

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Sauder's lack of faith in the possibility of a positive and autonomous birth experience in a hospital is what pushed her to look for alternative options. For her first birth in 2021, Sauder decided on a birthing center run by midwives.

Jaimi Sauder and her second child.

"From my research, [it would] be harder to have a natural birth at a hospital than it would at a birth center, because a birth center is more natural-minded. They have birth tubs, a natural form of reducing pain, and they have nitrous oxide," Sauder said.

Sauder emphasized taking a holistic and natural approach to her first birth. She self-induced using castor oil as she embarked on what was ultimately a 38-hour labor. While Sauder was pleased she was able to deliver her first baby naturally at the birthing center, she didn't like every aspect of her birth experience.

"For [my] birthing center, they have eight different midwives, so you could have any of them. I don't know if I really like that model of care, because you

“If you’re farther than 15 minutes away from a hospital, you probably should think again before you attempt a home birth…Having seen firsthand how things can go bad quickly, I like the idea that there’s emergency care available to the mom and baby. I can’t foresee the same thing happening if [an emergency] would happen at home. How could you get the help you needed quick enough?”

Jaimi Sauder and her husband at the birthing center during Sauder’s first labor.

don’t really have continuous support, because you don’t know who’s going to be there at the time [of your labor]. So I ended up having someone that I didn’t even like—I had never met her before,” Sauder said. While this is not reflective of how all birthing centers operate, this was a central aspect of Sauder’s birthing experience.

When Sauder became pregnant for the second time, she decided to give birth at home instead. Home birth allows women an even higher degree of control over their birth experience. They can determine precisely who is in the room with them, how the room is organized, and the position they give birth in.

Jordan, who had three vastly different birth experiences herself—one emergency Cesarean section, one vaginal birth in the hospital, and one home birth—said that home birth was the only setting that provided her with a birth experience she looked back on fondly. “When I decided to have a home birth, I knew that I wasn’t going to have people in my space telling me that I can’t when I know that I could. I was left to just labor in my own house, alone, as exactly how I needed. [My] labor was pretty intense, but it still was nothing compared to what I experienced at the hospital,” Jordan said.

For both Sauder and Jordan, laboring at home allowed for a more comfortable and flexible birth process. Giving birth at home means that women dictate the rules of their own experiences.

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Notably, major concerns persist about the safety of home births. While home birth was able to provide individuals like Sauder and Jordan with a positive birth experience, legitimate concerns remain regarding the relationship between home birth, infant, and maternal mortality.

According to a study published in the American Journal of Obstetrics and Gynecology in 2020, the infant mortality rate for in-hospital midwife-attended births in the United States was 3.27 per 10,000 live births, while the infant mortality rate for planned home births was 13.66 per 10,000 live births. The gap in outcomes is central to other, more critical perspectives on home birth. Many view the choice to give birth at home as irresponsible.

Glass maintained that the hospital remains the safest place to give birth. “Birthing is natural, and usually there is no problem, but if there is a problem, it happens fast. It’s good to know that there’s the needed interventions there to help you through your problems,” Glass said, “If you’re farther than 15 minutes away from a hospital, you probably should think again before you attempt a home birth…Having seen firsthand how things can go bad quickly, I like the idea that there’s emergency care available to the mom and baby. I can’t foresee the same thing happening if [an emergency] would happen at home. How could you get the help you needed quick enough?”

Even advocates for home birth acknowledge that the hospital may be safer for those giving birth, especially those who have “high-risk” pregnancies. A high-risk pregnancy occurs when the pregnant individual has certain health conditions, and involves increased health risks for the pregnant individual, the fetus, or sometimes both. Conditions that make pregnancy high risk include autoimmune diseases, high blood pressure, diabetes, polycystic ovary syndrome (PCOS), preeclampsia, and multiple gestation, amongst others. Approximately 30,000 to 50,000 Americans have high-risk pregnancies each year.

Although Jordan is a doula who advocates strongly for home birth as an available and accessible option, she recognized that the home may not always be the safest setting for childbirth. “True emergencies do happen, and there are high-risk people who should be in a hospital setting. There are also people who are perfectly low risk, but they feel better in a hospital setting,” Jordan said.

It’s important to note that while there may be disparities in neonatal mortality rates based on birth setting within the U.S., there seems to be less of a gap when looking at

Jaimi Sauder with her youngest daughter, who she gave birth to at home.

high-income countries generally. A study published in the journal *Midwifery* did not find significant differences in neonatal mortality rates between planned home births and hospital births. This study also showed that those with planned hospital births had lower odds of normal vaginal birth as compared to other planned births in different settings. The higher safety observed in home births in other high-income countries suggests that factors such as healthcare infrastructure and accessibility to trained midwives may play a critical role in minimizing risks.

There is no one right option for the best, safest place to give birth. While people may fall at each end of a spectrum, in reality, there is no birth completely free of risk—which means that the choice between hospital and home birth ultimately depends on individual circumstances, preferences, and access to resources.

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The drive for American women to reclaim autonomy over their birth experience is far from new. The modern home birth movement calls for a shift back to a much older model of labor—one that once defined childbirth in America. In the 19th century, nearly all births in the U.S. occurred in the home, led by women midwives. However, by the early 20th century, male physicians framed midwife-attended home birth as dangerous. Instead, physicians encouraged women to give birth in hospitals. By the 1960s, 99% of births occurred in the hospital.

According to Tannenbaum, the modern shift back toward natural home birth began around 50 years ago. "This modern shift back to home birth starts in the 60s and 70s with second-wave feminism and the American leftist counterculture," Tannenbaum said, "There was also the Women's Health Movement which encourages women to know and understand their own bodies and to take control away from doctors."

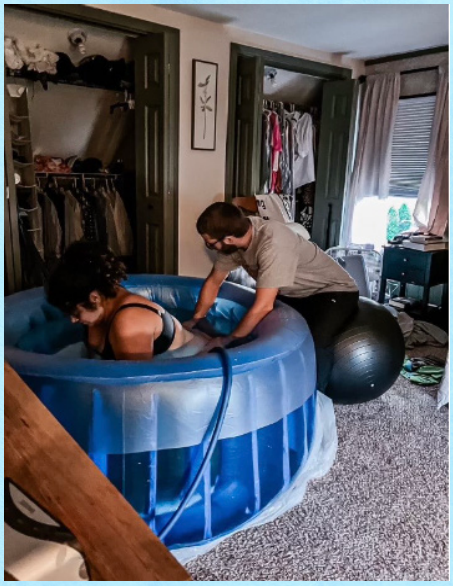
These movements in the mid- to late-19th century re-emphasized birth as a natural process, one overly-pathologized by the medical community. The shift back towards home birth, as well as the popularization of a natural form of birth preparation called lamaze, reflected a dissatisfaction with the medical establishment of the time. Counterculture and feminist movements struck a chord with women, and left many looking to reclaim power over their own reproductive experiences.

The home birth movement was not restricted to leftist or women's liberation groups. Rather, these groups found an unlikely ally in the Christian fundamentalist movement.

Both the feminist movement and Christian fundamentalists share a distrust of medical institutions. Feminists emphasized that childbirth has historically been attended by female midwives. In the 19th century, women had their authority in the delivery room taken from them by male physicians. Feminists of the 1970s called for a return to this traditional model of birth, wherein women delivered their babies in the home, surrounded by other women.

Christian movements' calls for a return to traditional birthing methods advocate for a similar outcome, but with vastly different motivations. "A lot of fundamentalist Christian families do home birth because they don't trust large institutions. But also because [child

"[One] thing that the two movements have in common is that Christian home birthers often say, 'God designed my body to give birth,'" Tannenbaum said, "And you see that in second-wave feminist writings about childbirth: your body is designed by nature to give birth, and we shouldn't define this as pathological. And [pathologizing childbirth] gives men control over our bodies, which we don't want."



Jaimi Sauder pictured with her husband during her home birth.

Jaimi Sauder holding her second-born daughter after her home birth as her oldest daughter watches.

Jaimi Sauder with her second-born daughter following her home birth.

birth] is something that's within the family, that's within the household—part of the patriarchal family. The father should be there and supervise the birth," Tannenbaum said.

Christian rhetoric is imbued throughout many popular home birth blogs. These blogs tend to reflect the idea that God designed the body for childbirth, while also emphasizing that the father of the child should be present to support in prayer. These blogs also recommend trusting in God's plan to provide safety and health during birth, rather than relying on medical institutions.

Both movements emphasize the fact that childbirth is ultimately a natural human process which does not necessarily require intervention by medical practitioners.

"[One] thing that the two movements have in common is that Christian home birthers often say, 'God designed my body to give birth,'" Tannenbaum said, "And you see that in second-wave feminist writings about childbirth: your body is designed by nature to give birth, and we shouldn't define this as pathological. And [pathologizing childbirth] gives men control over our bodies, which we don't want."

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The trend of home births in the United States seems unlikely to abate anytime soon. Many advocates argue, then, the next step is to make home births safer and more accessible.

"The thing that could improve outcomes for women is to have [home birth] be more accepted by the medical profession. It would be great if we had a system that does exist in some European countries, for instance, where nurse midwives will do home births and that's kind of the norm, unless you are a high risk birth," Tannenbaum said.

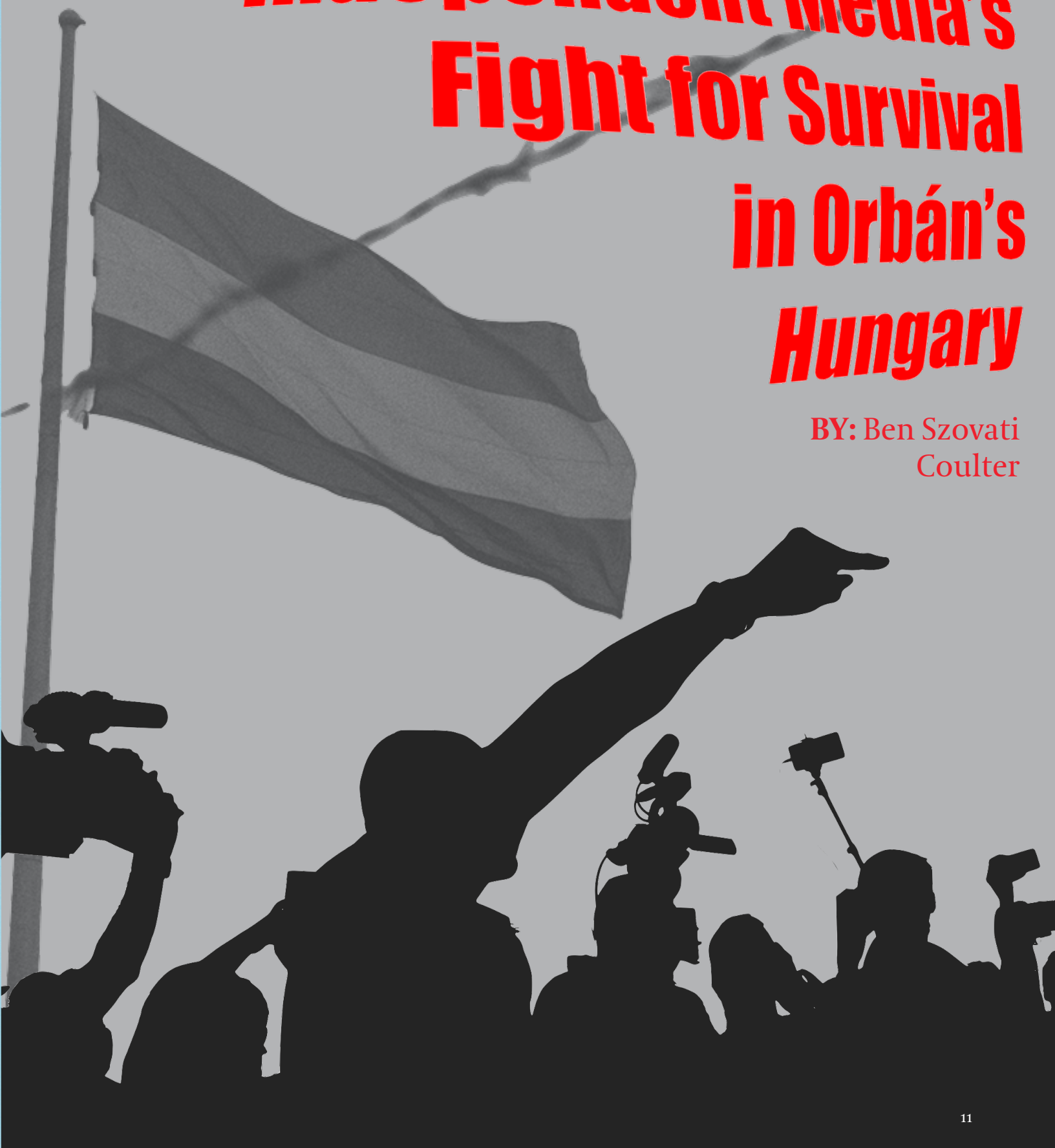
Glass holds a slightly different vision for what the future of birth could look like in the U.S.. She maintained that hospitals should play the defining role in childbirth. Glass said hospitals are adapting to changing desires related to childbirth experiences and can continue doing so.

"Hospitals are aware that women are wanting to have a natural birth, so some are trying to accommodate this by having areas within their maternity section that replicate a home birth as close as possible, with water tubs, allowing all the family in a room, a queen size bed, and nurses that understand that this mother wants to have a natural birth. More hospitals can adopt this model," Glass said.

As the popularity of home births increases, the demand for birthing options that balance autonomy with medical support grows. The ultimate goal should be to create a medical system wherein all women can have a birthing experience that not only ensures health for the mother and child but also honors their autonomy. This system need not choose between hospital and home birth, but rather create opportunities for women to be safe and healthy in whatever birth setting they choose.

The Silent Backslide: Independent Media's Fight for Survival in Orbán's Hungary

BY: Ben Szovati Coulter



"I used to believe the media is above power, but it has become clear to me that this is not the case," said Dominik Varga. Varga, whose name was changed to ensure his personal safety, is a veteran radio host in the Western Hungarian town of Győr.

Varga, like many Hungarian journalists, works for a government-funded municipal media group which is primarily responsible for city and provincial-level reporting. In Győr, the city council is dominated by Prime Minister Viktor Orbán's FIDESZ party. Over the past decade, the administration transformed municipal media into the party's private mouthpiece, and Varga had no choice but to take part.

"We regularly receive finished articles from city hall that we are obliged to publish. There is no opportunity for us to alter them in any way. On the radio, we enjoy a little bit more freedom, but here, too, our news reports are distorted," Varga said, "We are only allowed to communicate stories that serve those who are currently in power. Nothing about the opposition, or only information that criticizes them."

Varga still remembers the days of 1989. After decades of Soviet domination, Hungary was declared a republic, with freedom of speech and protection of the free press firmly enshrined in the nation's constitution. "A completely new world unfolded in front of us" and "the media was reborn," Varga said. Fresh out of high school and captured by the "magic" of a new democratic epoch, Varga decided journalism was his calling.

Today, three and a half decades later, he says, "there is no press freedom in Hungary."

Hungary is often described by scholars as an illiberal democracy. The term refers to nations where elections take place in the context of backsliding democratic rights and systems. As Fareed Zakaria (YC '86 and former Editor-in-Chief of The Politic) put it, elections in illiberal democracies "are free, but also profoundly unfair."

Magyars regularly head to the polls, yet one man, Viktor Orbán, has remained Prime Minister for the past 14 years. Hungary is no regional superpower—its population barely scrapes 9.5 million. But the country is a member of both NATO and the EU, where Orbán has often single-handedly obstructed funding to Ukraine and has been widely criticized for his close relations with autocrats and alleged embezzlement of EU funds. Orbán's ability to stay at the top of Hungarian politics is no accident. Since taking office in 2012, he has packed courts with sympathizers and altered the electoral system in favor of his party, FIDESZ. The most important implement in his anti-democratic toolkit, however, has been the complete subjugation of Hungarian media.

Since taking power in 2010, the Orbán government has engaged in a war of takeovers across the private sector, building a government-friendly media empire that spans the entire country.

"There i

In 2016, Hungary's oldest daily newspaper, Népszabadság, stopped publishing after an Orbán-linked oligarch acquired it and 16 other provincial papers. In 2018, a group of FIDESZ-friendly media owners simultaneously donated their outlets to the Central European Press and Media Foundation (KESMA), consolidating 500 national and local news services under the umbrella of government control. Orbán designated the deal a matter of "national strategic importance," allowing KESMA to circumvent antitrust investigation by the Hungarian Competition Authority.

"Those in power have realized that if they seize control of the press, they kill many flies with one hit. Accountability ceases. There remains nobody who can write unfavorable stories, nobody to hold the government to account," Varga said.

"No opposition force can gain strength, because they can't reach the people..."

In the run up to the 2022 elections, Hungary saw the "first serious" political challenger to Orbán emerge. Péter Márki-Zay, a mayor from the Southeastern city of Hódmezővásárhely, united the six largest opposition parties in an alliance against FIDESZ. Over the course of his campaign, state-television gave Márki-Zay a mere five-minute interview.

"No opposition force can gain strength, because they can't reach the people…They are not on TV, they are not in newspapers, you can't hear them on the radio. Their agenda simply does not reach the people," Varga said.

Márki-Zay's challenge to Orbán collapsed after his coalition won only 57 of the 199 seats in parliament. Orbán and his FIDESZ party won 135.

I asked Varga what would happen to him if he went against the instructions of his editors, commandeering his radio show to critique Győr's city hall or the national government. He responded without hesitation: "I would be fired instantly. It is also highly likely that I would not find a job anywhere else. FIDESZ controls a very, very large part of the media."

In Hungary, the provision of radio frequencies, along with the regulation of the media landscape as a whole, falls under the purview of the National Media and Infocommunications Authority (NMHH), established in 2010 as part of the freshly victorious FIDESZ party's raft of new media laws.

s no press freedom in Hungary."

Among other controversial decisions, in 2021, the NMHH Media Council made global headlines for its decision to revoke the broadcast license of Klubrádió, Hungary's last major independent radio station.

The official line from the regulator is that Klubrádió's administrative errors in submitting an "incorrect tender" resulted in their frequency rights being revoked. However, critics including the European Commission argue that rules were applied "in a disproportionate and discriminatory manner." Klubrádió's appeal to the Hungarian Supreme Court was ultimately struck down.

The President of the NMHH is a man by the name of Dr. András Koltay. Koltay, who also serves as the head of the NMHH's "Media Council," its five-member decision making body, was nominated for the NMHH presidency by Orbán. When I pressed Koltay on the impartiality of his organization, he explained the legal provisions governing the selection of the NMHH leadership.

"The President and members of the Media Council are confirmed by the Parliament. If we look at it from a formal legal perspective, we could not have a stronger authority than this," Koltay said, "Of course, those who don't accept this say that FIDESZ has a decisive majority in the Parliament and candidates are not confirmed through a full consensus. I don't know if there is any parliament in the world where decisions are made with complete consensus. Other than China or North Korea."

Responding to allegations regarding the politicization of the NMHH, Koltay responded firmly. "I have never received phone calls from politicians, they don't come here, I don't go to them," he said. Meanwhile, on the Klubrádió ruling, the Hungarian Government has been referred to the Court of Justice of the EU for breaching the union's communications laws.

Though the NMHH's actions may abide by specific administrative regulations, observers question whether the authority is living up to the spirit of its mandate. The NMHH's mission statement includes preserving "democratic publicity in the media" and "freedom of the press."

When speaking with Koltay, I cited multiple examples of journalists I spoke to being forced to publish stories or threatened by editors with termination. "This is not a matter related to the NMHH," Koltay responded, "If this journalist came to us, there would be nothing we could do. These are disagreements within media organizations."

Koltay did note protections within Hungarian law which prevent editors from threatening journalists, but he questioned its alleged underutilization. "I do not know of anyone who has used this rule over the last 14 years…One would expect journalists to stand up in defense of their rights," he said.

Varga serves as proof for why resisting the system is so difficult. As a dad raising two young children, permanently losing his job in the Hungarian radio is a risk too big to take.

The pursuit of truth in a Hungary ruled by Viktor Orbán often pushes journalists to make an impossible tradeoff: integrity or survival.

I asked Varga whether he believes maintaining one's job and preserving journalistic ethics are mutually exclusive in Hungary. He hesitated before responding, "There is a Hungarian saying: your mouth doesn't open, your head doesn't hurt. As a journalist, if you want to go to bed at night with your heart at ease, the only road you have is to stay apolitical." When given editorial discretion, Varga steers his radio show away from anything related to politics.

In this landscape, journalists who chase after government corruption and abuse of power are few and far between.

András Pethő, Editor-in-Chief of Direkt36, a non-profit investigative journalism center, is one of them. Pethő, a Harvard Niemann Fellow, co-founded Direkt36 after spending 10 years at Origo, one of Hungary's most-read online papers. He left after Origo's owner, Magyar Telekom, came under the influence of Orbán's Chief of Staff in a back-channel quid pro quo. In exchange for license renewal and a lucrative broadband installation contract, Magyar Telekom was to expunge journalism critical of the government.

"It became clear that the circumstances were not there anymore to conduct independent journalism," Pethő said. At the time of the deal, Pethő was working on an article exposing a misuse of government funds by Orbán's Chief of Staff.

"I would be fired instantly. It is also highly likely that I would not find a job anywhere else."

Upper management demanded the article be taken down. "When we pushed back with my colleagues, the editorial chief was forced out of his job. I resigned," Pethő said. 30 other colleagues walked out with him. Origo was eventually sold to the son of György Matolcsy, the Governor of the Hungarian Central Bank, and later donated to the KESMA media empire.

Péter Szigeti, the Director of 24.hu, the most widely accessed independent news outlet in Hungary, breaks down Hungary's media landscape into three categories: public service, commercial, and provincial. 24.hu belongs to the commercial group, and unlike Origo, it is one of the few in this category that managed to stay free from Orbán's mass accretion of media outlets.

Szigeti attributes 24.hu's success in avoiding a takeover to the organization's self-reliance. "Céntral Media (the owner of 24.hu) is a profitable company. We can make a living on the market," Szigeti said.

Many smaller outlets can not achieve the same. The largest domestic advertiser in Hungary is the government, a position they exploit to financially strangle dissident outlets. A study by independent media watchdog Mérték estimates 90% of state advertisements are distributed to FIDESZ-friendly organizations. Even though 24.hu reaches 75% of Hungarian internet users, "we receive nothing," Szigeti said.

During our interview, Szigeti took a pause and smiled at his clock. "Actually, the time window is just starting," he said, "At the moment, it is 3:30pm on Friday. At around 4pm, when they believe our lawyers are beginning to head home, [the lawsuits] arrive." The timing is no accident; 24.hu has five days to respond to government lawsuits, and two valuable days will be lost during the weekend. Szigeti continued, "They use public funds to hire expensive lawyers and law firms to sue for everything in the name of those in power." 24.hu's legal team, meanwhile, is a handful of law school seniors. The outlet has not lost a single case this year.

While Szigeti takes a lighthearted approach to the barrage of lawsuits that hit 24.hu each week, other papers may not have this opportunity for levity. In 2021, Direkt36 was embroiled in a scandal that struck at the very heart of Hungarian power. After being contacted by a French investigative outlet, it was revealed that two Direkt36 journalists were surveilled by the Hungarian security services using Pegasus, an Israeli-made anti-terror spyware. Pegasus—the maker of which is blacklisted by the U.S. Government—has the ability to access messages, harvest photos, and activate a device's camera and microphone undetected. "I wasn't surprised, let's put it this way," Pethő said, "But, I was still shocked that they deployed a military grade… cyber weapon against journalists who were just doing their job and reporting on stories that were clearly in the public interest. They did this in a country that is….still supposed to be a democracy."

"I was still shocked that they deployed a military grade…cyber weapon against journalists who were just doing their job."

The government does everything they can to prevent 24.hu from doing their job. "Instead of putting journalists in prison, they don't speak to them," Szigeti said, "It makes our work a lot more difficult. What happens is you send a question to a government ministry, and they simply don't respond. They also make accessing public information remarkably difficult." In a bid to burden private news outlets, the Hungarian government has begun charging for access to normally free public data such as company registrations or land ownership records.

However, according to Szigeti, "The biggest problem for the Hungarian media market and democracy is not that the government interferes with our operations. The real big problem is that classical public broadcasters have been destroyed."

In the leadup to the recent U.S. Presidential Election, Hungarian state television showed no restraint in taking sides. In a report introducing the two candidates, each was described with three phrases which flashed up on

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the screen. President-elect Trump—a close ally of Orbán—was assigned "protective tariffs, peace, border security." Vice President Harris was assigned "climate crisis, war, abortion."

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In the face of heavily distorted journalism, the Hungarian regulator appears paralyzed in its approach. "It is concerning and problematic from many perspectives, but at the same time, this can't be dealt with through legal means. I think this is an issue of journalistic ethics and societal culture," Koltay said, "A media authority is not equipped to take over the role of the editors. This would be serious interference with the freedom of a media outlet."

Referencing media magnate and majority owner of Fox Corporation, Rupert Murdoch, Koltay said that "at the end of the day, the word of the owner decides what happens in an organization...You could call this unpleasant or immoral, but nobody disputes that this is within [Murdoch's] rights. This is part of press freedom too."

Institutional biases are inevitable, but as Szigeti pointed out, journalistic independence does not absolve journalistic malpractice. "In a story, you listen to every impacted party and separate news from opinion. These are basic rules," he said. Prior to the 2022 Hungarian elections, newspapers, radio, and television stations across the country broadcast that Márki-Zay would send Hungarians to fight in Ukraine if he won the election. Márki-Zay never made such a claim.

"The fact that any political force can be the owner of a media group is a very big problem," Varga said.

Pethő says the question of whether there is freedom of the press in Hungary is difficult. "I think another way of asking this is whether the press is able to fulfill its democratic function," he said, "I have more doubts about that."

Koltay goes as far as saying that "the people aren't really interested anymore in whether there can be unbiased news broadcasts." But, as Dominik Varga still believes, "press freedom has to be the foundational pillar of democracy."

Looking to the future, Koltay, Szigeti, and Varga all agree that the prospect for change is small. "We Hungarians are generally pessimists," Koltay laughed, "You need well-trained journalists with their heart in the right place. You need a market which is large enough to sustain itself. You need self-conscious consumers who are willing to pay to support the media…The conditions are missing."

"I don't have any illusions," Szigeti said, "If one day someone else is in power in Hungary, I don't think they would release this [the public broadcasters] from their grip."

"The chance of [change] is very small," Varga agreed. Referencing the Hungarian Revolution of 1848, "Only the people can initiate this change," he said, "If the Hungarian people throw their hands on the table and say, that's enough, we want an independent media…then maybe the free press could come back to Hungary."

In spite of this outlook, Direkt36 and 24.hu continue their missions.

"Last year, we did a story on hospital-acquired infections, and it resonated really, really widely. We even saw some changes announced by the government," Pethő recounted.

At 24.hu, reporters are coming up with creative ways to access information. "If they don't give you the details on what type of estate the Prime Minister is building, then you realize you can go there yourself and take photos with a drone," Szigeti said, "You stand at a specific spot from morning to night waiting for [your subject]."

These tactics have come to define the new style of reporting in Hungary. "I still remember the times when it was not like this," Szigeti said, "but [the younger generation] don't… They have learned to adapt."

The work of brave, seasoned journalists like Szigeti, Pethő, and Varga and hundreds of intrepid, young Hungarians keep the embers of democratic hope alive. Embers, centuries of Hungarian history prove, can flare into light.

** Interviews with Varga, Koltay, and Szigeti were conducted in Hungarian and translated to English

Abort or Engage

The Landscape of Abortion Dialogue at Yale

By Kiran Yeh

In the spring of her sophomore year, Hyerim Bianca Nam '24 encountered a tabling event on Yale's Cross Campus. The students at the table invited passersby to engage in conversations about abortion ethics and fetal personhood. Images of sonograms and fetal diagrams sprawled across the poster board.

These student volunteers belonged to an organization called Choose Life at Yale (CLAY), a pro-life student group dedicated to "upholding the dignity of human life through [...] meetings, discussions, events, and support of policies to ease the difficulties of pregnancy on campus."

The event took place during Yale's Bulldog Days for admitted students in April 2022, just before the leak of the draft decision of Dobbs v. Jackson Women's Health Organization, which ruled that the Constitution does not confer a right to abortion.

In an interview with The Politic, Nam recalled beginning a conversation with the CLAY advocates despite disagreeing with their message. She found that the student representatives were courteous and spoke carefully. However, throughout the discussion, which lasted approximately 5-10 minutes, she recounted, "The more I tried to speak, they refused to address what I had said. Instead, [they] suggested that we start talking about something else. I felt silenced and ignored." By the end of their exchange, Nam felt that the representatives had purposely driven a strong emotional response out of her. She resigned in anger.

"The more I tried to speak, they refused to address what I had said. Instead, [they] suggested that we start talking about something else. I felt silenced and ignored."

Nam found this "constant redirection" one of the most frustrating aspects of their conversation. For example, Nam remembers challenging members of CLAY, asking, "Where does a woman's right to choose come into this? Why do you think that the government has the right to tell a woman what to do and what not to do with her body?" The answer she received from the members was a question in response. They would ask her, "What do you think makes a human in the first place? What do you think makes a person?"

A year later, Nam conducted an admissions interview as an alumna for the high school Telluride Association Summer Program (TASS). The student she interviewed expressed hope and excitement that they would engage in conversations with people holding different perspectives. Nam was reminded of her own experience with CLAY.

While she knew the interview was not the right setting for a political discussion, she reflected on what the high schooler had expressed. Then in her third year, she realized how widespread this desire for "open dialogue" was among young people—particularly at Yale, where debate is widely encouraged.

Nam was brought back to her interaction with CLAY and remembered her exasperation. Slowly, she came to realize that she disagreed with the view of conversation for conversation's sake. "When it comes to highly divisive issues, especially like abortion, [the] conversation can impede communication, and all it does is further alienate people who are on opposite sides of the debate," she said.

On April 11, 2023, Nam published an opinion piece in The Yale Daily News (YDN) titled "Abort the Conversation." She concluded her article by writing, "We can't all be saviors. Some people are only interested in pulling us below the surface of the water. Let go of the line of thinking. Abort the conversation."

Shortly after her piece was published, Nam received support and criticism from her peers and others beyond Yale. In addition to being sent emails, others made more public comments.

Michael Samaritano '24 wrote a response article in the YDN, titled "A conversation we should not kill," arguing that the "larger risk is to be found in uncritically accepting beliefs about the most important questions of human existence." Meanwhile, Nam's article circulated multiple blogs, such as Ethics Alarms, and readers left comments about her, her family, and her background.

One commenter wrote, "The biatch has already spent three years at Yale, why not broaden her educational experience and wrap it all up in North Korea?"

Nam maintains that abortion debates threaten human rights and should not take place at all. But it is inevitable that the broader dispute about abortion—how it should be discussed, if at all—will continue to persist.

Abortion remains a central issue in American politics and a focal point in the nation's culture wars. In 2023, Tom Bonier, a Democratic political strategist, wrote for The New York Times that "abortion rights are the dominant issue in American politics." In recent exit polls, abortion was the second most important issue to Harris voters, and abortion rights referendums passed across seven states, four of which were traditionally conservative. Opinions on abortion often transcend strict party lines, differing along gender, race, and religion, and vary in terms of the level of restrictions people support.

At Yale, a campus that trends liberal, most students and faculty are in favor of individuals having access to abortions. While no official "pro-choice" organization exists, being pro-choice is often seen as a norm. "Not everyone on this campus is pro-choice—sometimes that alone surprises students," wrote Kylyn Smith '26, CLAY's

"When it comes to highly divisive issues, especially like abortion, [the] conversation can impede communication, and all it does is further alienate people who are on opposite sides of the debate."

Summer Logistics Coordinator, in an email to The Politic. Still, Yale students hold diverse perspectives on the issue of abortion itself and vary on how such conversations should be approached.

For CLAY, hosting tabling events like the one Nam experienced during Bulldog Days "[inputs] an often under-voiced point of view into campus dialogue dominated by the pro-choice perspective," wrote Emma Ventresca '26, President of CLAY, in an email to The Politic. While Nam had multiple peers confide in her that if they saw the table as an admitted student, they would reconsider committing, CLAY advocates asserted the opposite. Ventresca said, "I remember one student [...] who said he didn't know Yale had people like us, and it made him want to attend. The CLAY table not only stood for the pro-life cause for him but also for a campus open to free speech and open exchange."

These tabling events are not a practice exclusive to Bulldog Days—CLAY hosts them monthly in addition to engaging in service projects, holding candlelit vigils, and organizing an annual pro-life conference, Vita et Veritas. CLAY hosts training to prepare volunteers for these events "based upon concrete facts and a developed understanding of this complex issue," Ventresca said. "During our programming, we discuss how to have compassionate, enlightening discussions with strangers and friends alike and develop a greater understanding of important pro-life talking points through statistics and testimonies."

Like Nam, many members of the Yale community have expressed overt discontent toward CLAY's tabling events. Ventresca noted that students occasionally approach the table and crumple their flyers or take photos of their displays to send to their friends. "It is hard for people, even intelligent people at Yale, to learn that there are equally intelligent people who have a different opinion on a controversial topic," wrote Smith. "It should be easy for people, however —especially intelligent people at Yale—to react with decency when faced with polite opposition."

Ventresca also recalled feeling "unsettled" by some of the conversations that she had herself. She remembered when a student came to the table "cynically." When Ventresca asked the student what an abortion was, the student replied that it was a woman's right to choose. Ventresca had hoped to talk about the medical procedure of abortion but felt that the student needed to "come to the table with a clear understanding of what abortion is," and people who approach them should be "willing to hear out each other's understandings, [and] not just a vague abstraction of the topic."

Despite this, Ventresca stressed the importance of these events, since, "[a]bortion is an issue that affects college communities and having honest, open discussions is the best way to foster a culture of life on campuses." She recounted when a friend saw her tabling event and spoke to her for nearly half an hour. Even though he did not have experience with either side of the argument, and felt like he did not have a say because he was not a woman, he willingly embraced her perspective. "My friend could have pretended he didn't recognize me. But instead, he decided to come over and engage in a very difficult discussion. I gave him a hug at the end of our talk," said Ventresca.

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While CLAY tries to make its presence visible on campus, writing the organization's name in chalk in front of the central Sterling Memorial Library, other student groups also work to add to the discussion. Among undergraduates, the Planned Parenthood Student-Advocates at Yale facilitate internship opportunities at the New Haven chapter and advocate for reproductive rights within the community. Their mission statement states they "strive to engage in open and respectful conversations at Yale and in the greater New Haven community to challenge stigma misconceptions around reproductive health, rights, and access."

Beyond the College, the School of Public Health hosts the activism group Reproductive Health Equity Now (RHEN), which promotes access to reproductive health care, including maternal health, abortion, and contraception. Their mission is to emphasize a public health perspective, highlighting the dangers of abortion bans and the importance of safe, accessible reproductive health services. |

RHEN's leadership noted that as an organization, they approach the conversation from a healthcare standpoint. "We do not engage with any sort of opposition," said co-leader Amelia Apgar YSPH '25. "However, we equip our members with the tools and strategies that they need to be effective advocates in the face of opposition." Apgar added that from this lens, the discussion surrounding abortion should be private. "Any moral or legal considerations are just null in the face of healthcare," she said. To Apgar, all reproductive health decisions should be made solely between a person and their doctor.

Nevertheless, there is an understanding that it can be difficult for individuals to separate the moral aspect of the conversation, according to Co-Leader Kaustubha Gajjala YSPH '25. good way to connect with people on moral issues is by giving them the facts and using public health-focused initiatives," she noted.

However, Apgar noted that in her personal life, she engages in conversations with those who disagree with her view on reproductive health. "I take it very seriously, and [I] respect others' opinions and see what work we can still do, although we disagree. There's a lot of room, I think, for positive advocacy and change, even when people might not be 100% on your side."

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In late October, CLAY hosted its annual Vita et Veritas conference, "Dispelling the Myths of the Abortion Narrative," and presented an

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"Any moral or legal considerations are just null in the face of healthcare."

array of speakers including activists, an attorney, and an OB-GYN.

One of the speakers, Dr. Catherine Wheeler, an OB-GYN with 24 years of experience, spoke in a "raw and real [way] that many students have probably not been exposed to before," according to Ventresca. At the conference, she spoke mostly about abortion procedures, including the use of instruments and the emotional toll on providers. Not only did she come from a healthcare perspective, but she had also been exposed to two vastly different sides of the spectrum—from performing abortions to advocating against them.

After attending the conference, Dr. Wheeler spoke to The Politic. She shared that she underwent cognitive dissonance while performing abortions for fifteen years, which ultimately led her to question and reject her beliefs.

Dr. Wheeler also shared her personal experiences as a mother, emphasizing the need to broaden the conversation beyond abortion to include how to support pregnancies better. She recounted her own challenges with unexpected and high-risk pregnancies, including a ruptured membrane before viability and multiple miscarriages. She also spoke about overcoming extreme poverty during her first two pregnancies. "In my first unplanned pregnancy, I heard the narrative from the media, 'You can't do this,'" she remembered. "But my best friend stood with me and said, 'You're going to be a great mom.'"

As someone who previously performed abortions, Dr. Wheeler feels she understands pro-choice advocates. "I honestly believe most people, like me, think they're helping women. Most people care deeply about women and the harms that are being done to women, especially women [who] get abandoned when they're pregnant," she said. "I get it, but our job as a society is to stand beside them and to help them, not tell them your best option is to take the life of your baby."

More than anything, Dr. Wheeler advises approaching conversations with grace. "People believe things for a reason. We've got to get back to open dialogue, trying to understand each other as human beings, and being willing to have conversations even when they're hard, even when they bring up something difficult," she said.

Like Ventresca and Apgar, Dr. Wheeler suggested examining official research studies from both sides to make informed arguments. "Look for things that are true, not what makes me feel good about it," she said. "We're not here to win conversations. We're here to try to come to the truth."

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Nam's perspective—that of denouncing conversations about abortion entirely—is unpopular. Jack Marshall, an ethicist who runs the blog Ethics Alarms, published a post in April 2023 responding to Nam's article. Marshall wrote, "That is where her Yale education has brought her in less than three years. She won't swerve from that one-way world view in the time remaining, because she has learned that arguments that might change her mind—anyone else's, presumably, are dangerous. She is a young, emerging totalitarian."

Despite the harsh criticism, Nam holds fast to her original stance. She understands that people hold a right to free speech, but, to her, the ideas that pro-lifers espouse create an unsafe and threatening space. She argues that sharing these thoughts is, in fact, antithetical to the idea of open speech. In her experience, "by refusing to engage with the questions of human rights and bodily autonomy that are central to this debate," they are suppressing free expression. "I fully embrace every single word that I wrote," said Nam.

The conversation surrounding abortion will live on. Ultimately, it is up to Yale students, and the rest of the country, to decide how—and if—they want to engage.

"People believe things for a reason. We've got to get back to open dialogue, trying to understand each other as human beings, and being willing to have conversations even when they're hard, even when they bring up something difficult."

Unfair Use: The Struggle for Ownership in the Age of AI

By: Aubrie Williams

If not for several calls for interview requests from various news outlets, artist Erin Hanson might have never known that her career's work was being trained and recreated on the AI platform Stable Diffusion. Hanson, a prominent modern artist known for her invention of the "open impressionism" painting style, produced thousands of oil paintings in her nearly two-decade career. But Hanson's distinctive style, which is marked by vibrant and expressive landscapes, was so closely replicated by Stable Diffusion that she couldn't help but feel impressed. "It was pretty amazing," Hanson said. "Obviously, I'm an artist. I know what an original oil painting looks like, and I can tell when something's been computer-generated. But someone not in the know might go, 'Oh yeah, that looks like a painting by Erin Hanson.'"

Hanson stands beside her 2024 painting "Impressions of France." (Source: David Bates, Oregon ArtsWatch -- Arts and Culture News)

But Hanson's initial admiration couldn't overshadow her concern about the liberal use of her intellectual property. "The issue I have with [generative AI] is when people then sell the image. That's where copyright violation comes into play," said Hanson. "It's one thing to use. You know, anyone can copy art for their own personal use. That's not illegal. It's only a problem when you then try to sell it."

Hanson's story is just one of many in the ongoing battle between creators and AI companies that depend on vast, often copyrighted, data to train their machines. Copyright law in the United States grants creators exclusive rights to the reproduction, distribution and derivatives of their original work. If a company wanted to use an artists' work for commercial purposes, they would be legally obligated to obtain the creator's permission, and, in most cases, provide compensation. Creators' rights to the reproduction and distribution of their work are at the center of the suits leveled against AI companies.

One particularly notable case is the ongoing The New York Times v. Open AI. The New York Times alleges that in response to certain prompts, popular chatbot ChatGPT's output recites articles verbatim. The Times' ability to cite specific examples of ChatGPT parroting its articles make its case a particularly strong one in the battle between writers and AI. Yet there remain nuances to the lawsuit. Jane Friedman, co-founder of publishing-industry newsletter The Hot Sheet, said, "The New York Times has been accused of manipulating the prompts to such an extent that they are trying to get an infringing result. It's not like you can easily get these models to regurgitate." But Friedman acknowledged that to many, this doesn't change the fundamental violation of the AI companies. "If the models can regurgitate, regardless, then…they're infringement machines, and you can't get past that."

New York Times v. Open AI is not the only copyright lawsuit taking place against AI models today. The explosion in popularity of these AI models three years ago sparked a veritable litigative reckoning against every aspect of their use. Some suits are concerned with the training process itself. Umair Kazi, Director of Policy and Advocacy at the Authors Guild, said that when an AI company "downloads illegal copies or unauthorized copies and makes further copies of those books in the course of training, that is copyright infringement." In other words, both the initial pirating of content and the additional copies made during training violate creators' exclusive rights to their works' reproduction.

AI companies are fighting back against these claims, though, on the grounds that their work constitutes fair use, a doctrine that allows limited use of copyrighted material without permission. The specific conditions protected under fair use include purposes of commentary, criticism, education, or transformative work. A landmark fair use case is Authors Guild, Inc. v. Google, Inc., which concerned Google's Google Books project. To create a searchable online database, Google scanned millions of copyrighted books. While the Authors Guild held that this project violated copyright law by reproducing and distributing authors' work without permission, the U.S. Court of Appeals ruled in favor of Google in 2015 on the fair use doctrine. The court held that the project was sufficiently transformative, as its purpose was to create a searchable database separate from what the original works offered.

But Kazi explained that new cases leveled against AI companies bear significant differences from the Google Books case. "There's just copying happening…and the copying facilitates the creation of new works that then compete in the market for words. So, it's hard to see what is transformative or what new medium is being added."

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Matthew Butterick is a lawyer working with Joseph Saveri Law Firm, which has fought a wave of intellectual property lawsuits against AI companies. Butterick is similarly suspicious of AI companies' fair use arguments. "If they're right, then that means that they get to use the data for free, forever, without asking anybody." Butterick continued, "These CEOs are standing up and saying, we're about to build the most valuable thing that capitalism has ever seen. Oh, but we can't pay for the copyrighted works. I think there's a huge amount of eye rolling."

This issue is especially personal for Butterick, who, in addition to being a lawyer, is also a designer, author and programmer. Specializing in typography, Butterick has released several typefaces and also penned a 2010 book titled Typography for Lawyers. He explained, "I noticed that my own work was in the data sets of all these models. So it was especially interesting to me, right? I mean, I could tell that my words were being quoted back to me by ChatGPT. It was a little alarming." Butterick added, "It was apparent to me that it was going to cause a very serious impact on creators of every kind, especially people of my stripe—independently self-employed creators. So, I reactivated my law license to get involved."

Butterick sees an exploitation of authentic creation at the heart of these AI technologies. "The term artificial intelligence itself is something of a misnomer," he said. "It's really human intelligence that's being moved from one location, passed through this software object." Butterick explained that despite the companies' promises of revolutionary societal change, they're still heavily dependent on human ideas. "These companies have no way right now to scale their business without this voracious appetite for human-created work."

AI generated painting in the style of Hanson using Stable Diffusion

W. Ralph Eubanks, a professor at the University of Mississippi and a member of the Author's Guild, also remains unconvinced by AI companies' claims about their software as a tool for creativity. Eubanks is currently writing a book about the Mississippi Delta, one chapter of which examines the town Mound Bayou. He uses his own research as an example to underscore a problem with AI-generated tools. "There [are] several books that I had to read on [Mound Bayou], just to get an idea of what was there… but by going to generative AI and getting something about Mound Bayou from it, I would have missed a lot of perspectives." When it comes to the creative process, Eubanks ultimately sees AI as ineffective and overcomplicated. His advice is pretty simple: "Read a book, that's my immediate reaction. Don't use [AI] to brainstorm."

Eubanks offers a unique perspective on the issue, as he grapples with AI both as a writer and as a professor. Fair use includes a major educational component; in other words, the use of copyrighted works is often permitted for educational purposes. But far from an aid, Eubanks has found AI to be an impediment to learning and development in the classroom. "I'm concerned about what this

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says to students about the craft of writing, that you can really begin a project without your own blood, sweat, toil, tears. That you can generate something and then maybe take it from there and go ahead. That's not how the best writing is produced." Ultimately, Eubanks sees AI companies' unauthorized use of writers' work as an erasure of a writer's legacy. If AI is permitted to freely use his and other authors' works, "my intellectual labor has not been compensated," Eubanks said. "When I'm not here, what my children inherit, it's not valuable. My life's work has no value."

Eubanks' concern underscores the deeply personal stakes in the fight over intellectual property rights; for many artists and writers, their work represents a lifetime of labor meant to be passed down. Yet from the perspective of AI models, even the most extensive collections are just a small fraction of the required data.

Jane Friedman explained, "The metaphor that I think has been most useful in understanding this is grains of sand on a beach. The model works when you give it the entire beach and it can extrapolate from there how to build lots of different things or output lots of different things. But no single grain by itself is particularly valuable." This means the bargaining power of one individual is relatively small. This complicates issues for creatives, many of whom are freelance or independent, who want credit for their works' contributions to the models.

As AI companies face mounting pressure over their data-training practices, some legal experts suggest collective action as a potential solution. James Grimmelmann, a professor at Cornell Law School, said, "It's one possibility to put some pressure on artists to come together into collective unions that can do AI licenses for all of those members. [It'll] capture some number of professional artists." But though this united front could offer some protection, the vast majority of online content creators would remain unprotected. "It's not going to capture you and me writing blog posts and social media posts that are public," said Grimmelman, highlighting a key challenge with no clear solution.

"Coastal Vista" by Erin Hansen

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Even as the dispute between creatives and AI companies grows increasingly fraught, artists are not letting it slow their craft. Hanson, who owns an art studio in Oregon, remains optimistic about the future of art. "[AI] certainly hasn't decreased my creativity in any way. I get my inspiration by going outside and looking at beautiful landscapes. I don't go online to get my inspiration," Hanson said. "I hope that our government will step up and do something to protect artists, but it's certainly not going to stop creativity... artists are artists. They're going to create no matter what."

Photo Credit: Delil Souleiman, August 2, 2021, Getty Images

Hells on Earth:

Forgottten Stories from the Middle East's Front Lines

Photo Credit: MacMillan Center for International and Area Studies at Yale

BY: Eliza Daunt

Photo Credit: 2019 Planet Labs

Photo Credit: 2019 Planet Labs

Roba El Husseini has spent the past decade with Agence France Presse (AFP) reporting from some of the world's most challenging conflict zones, covering crises in Syria, Lebanon, Iraq and beyond. Her reporting relays powerful stories of military operations, human tragedies, and systemic issues in the region, from the Syrian war to Lebanon's 2019 protests and its following economic fallout. Today, she is the AFP Deputy Bureau Chief in Baghdad but is taking a brief pause from her work to be a World Fellow here at Yale.

This interview has been edited for clarity.

Did your upbringing influence your approach to journalism?

I grew up in South Lebanon, so my childhood was tainted with wars, conflict, bombing, and displacement. Growing up in that situation, I wanted to understand the world better.
When you start journalism in a place like Lebanon and the Middle East, you are drawn to conflict without wanting it.

When I joined AFP, a whole journey started. A journey filled with, unfortunately, a lot of conflict and crises but the Middle East is also very vibrant, intertwined, rich with culture, tradition, and history.

Could you share insights from investigative stories that you've covered which had a significant impact on you?

In the last three years, with AFP, I focused on investigations, including one on Captagon, the highly addictive amphetamine drug that has taken the Middle East by storm. Around 80% is produced in Syria and its market is Saudi Arabia.

We did an investigation about the salt rooms in Sednaya prison, one of the Syrian regime's most notorious prisons, which was particularly hard. In 2017, Amnesty International reported that 13,000 people had been executed in that prison. In our investigation in 2022, we found out that there were rooms in the prison full of coarse salt to keep bodies from decomposing before sending them to mass graves.

We interviewed witnesses— – people who went into these salt rooms, who heard about them from other inmates, and even some tasted the salt because they weren't allowed any in the prison. I interviewed them multiple times, asking them to tell the story of one of their hardest traumas. How do you deal with that? They taught me how to interview them without knowing it. It is one of the stories that is stuck in my mind and my heart.

The last investigation I did was on October 13 last year when a group of journalists were hit by a strike in South Lebanon. A Reuters colleague and a friend of 15 years, Issam Abdallah, was killed. My two colleagues from AFP, Christina Assi and Dylan Collins, and three Al Jazeera colleagues were also wounded.

Photo Credit: Ivor Prickett, New York Times

It was a seven-week investigation that showed that it was Israeli shelling: two strikes. The first strike killed Issam and wounded Christina. It was one of the hardest things that I've ever had to do. I had to zoom in on pictures to identify the munition. It's not easy to investigate something that is really linked to you.

You spent several months investigating Al-Hol, a detention camp in Syria housing ISIS-affiliated individuals and their families. Can you describe it?

We have many hells on Earth in the Middle East now. Al Hol is one of them.

Al Hol was described to me as an open-air prison. When you cover front lines, you see death, wounded people, and wounded children. We try to deal with everything we see, but a land of children behind barbed wires who don't have the freedom to move or leave, that gets to you.

When I was covering the last battle against the Islamic State group five years ago, the captured families of the suspected fighters would ask me where they were being taken. I would say "They're taking you to Al Hol camp." They'd ask, "How long will we stay there?" "I don't know, but I don't assume long." Five years later, they are still there. Those who entered the camp when they were two years old are now seven.

When I got there, I knew right away that it was a camp for children. You enter the camp and the first thing you see is children: children working, children throwing stones, children everywhere.

> **"The children are left there, stuck in limbo, with a big stigma placed on them. "They are the children of the Islamic State group fighters." "They are bad." How can a five-year-old be bad?"**

We had to leave the camp before 3 pm. People tell me that when it's dark they hide in their tents because of the crimes and murders.

In that camp, children are paying the price for the sins of their fathers. They opened their eyes and they saw war, radicalism, angry mothers, tents, and camps.

The children of this camp are traumatized: they've seen bombardment, siege, and death. Now they are stuck in a place where they cannot go out. One mother told me that her child asked her if the tents inside the camp are better than the ones outside.

The camp is divided into the main camp and then the annex for foreigners. Could you describe this divide?

The main camp is where they, the US-backed Kurdish forces, keep the Syrian and Iraqi Islamic State families and displaced people. There are around 43,000 people in it—the great majority are children.

There is an annex for foreigners which now holds more than 6,000 people from around 50 countries. Name a country, and you have it in Al Hol's annex. There's also a smaller camp called Roj, which holds more than 2,000 foreigners.

From what I've seen, nationality brings

Photo Credit: Goran Tomasevic/Reuters

people together, but so does radicalism. The radicals stick together and those who are afraid of the radicals stick together.

A woman described the camp for me. She said people on the outside see us as one thing, but we are not. Some have become super radicalized because of this situation; others don't want anything to do with this anymore. People don't see this from the outside. They just see bad people. How bad can a child be?

The Kurdish security forces have imposed more restrictions on the annex than on the main camp. In the main camp, it's easier to engage with people and children want to talk to you. There was this 12-year-old kid, Ali. I was talking to his neighbor. She was telling me how Islamic State members had kidnapped her, beaten her, and shot her in the face and shoulder when she was only 18 years old. Then Ali interrupted and started explaining his own story.

But, when you go to the annex, to their marketplace, children will throw stones at you because they're bored, because they don't trust foreigners, because they have angry mothers, because they are growing up behind barbed wires.

What can the international community do for these children?

Al Hol has every issue you can find in a book—lack of education, complicated access to health care, poverty, sexual abuse. International organizations work there and there is so much for them to do but only so much that they can offer to children.

For example, there are educational programs, but then you have radical women who don't want their children to be educated at a program run by an international Western organization. Other women are too afraid to send their children to these small schools because Al Hol is bursting with crime. A 2022 report by Save the Children said that children have seen murders, kidnappings, stabbings, and strangulation on their way to school. I had women telling me that they keep their children inside their tent. It becomes a prison inside a prison.

The world isn't dealing with Al Hol. You have these speeches and statements about how "we" defeated the Islamic State group, but how are they dealing with this generation? How do they expect these children to grow up if they don't know anything beyond these barbed wires?

The Kurds, the UN, and the international organizations have all been calling on countries to repatriate their citizens. You cannot separate children from their mothers without adding traumas to these children, so the international community need to find a solution.

The children are left there, stuck in limbo, with a big stigma placed on them. "They are the children of the Islamic State group fighters." "They are bad." How can a five-year-old be bad? If you want to fix their future, you need to deal with their present now.

The camps are managed by the Kurdish-led Syrian Democratic Forces, the SDF, who allied with the US to combat ISIS. How has the war changed the way the Kurds are operating within the region?

Syrian Kurds have been marginalized for so long. They weren't allowed to study their language at school or celebrate their holidays, and so on.

Then, in 2012, the Syrian regime was losing and withdrew from the Kurdish-majority areas—that's when the Kurds prevailed. They formed a semi-autonomous administration and started ruling and expanding the Kurdish-majority areas. In 2014, they allied with the US and in 2019, defeated the Islamic State group. There are still around 900 U.S. personnel in the Kurdish-controlled areas in Syria. Now, after spearheading the battle against the Islamic State group, the Kurds look after the Western-funded camps and prisons where the IS fighters are kept.

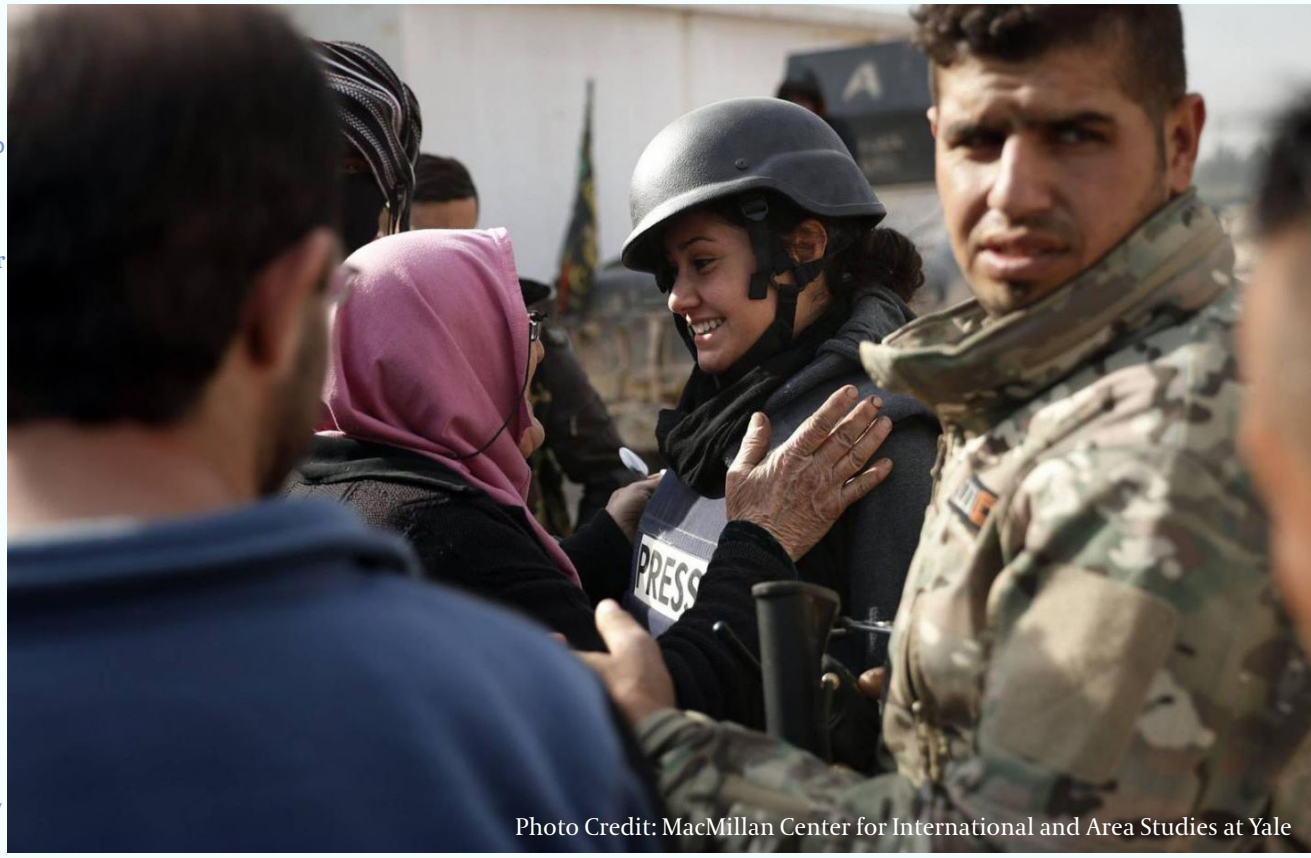


Photo Credit: MacMillan Center for International and Area Studies at Yale

What the future holds for the Syrian Kurds is a very big question. Everything has changed for them since 2012. It will be tough, but there will come a time when these negotiations will have to happen.

How might another Trump presidency impact the Syrian Kurds, given their concerns after the 2019 U.S. troop withdrawal and Turkey's subsequent invasion?

In 2019, Trump decided to withdraw U.S. troops from Kurdish-held areas along the border with Turkey. This decision paved the way for Turkey to launch an invasion that same year. Ankara considers Syria's Kurdish forces, the Syrian Democratic Forces, a terrorist group claiming that they are allied to the PKK (Kurdistan Workers' Party), a leftist Kurdish armed group that has been in conflict with Ankara since the 1980s.

“It hits you in the face every time there’s war.

The Kurds are worried that another Trump presidency will bring them something they cannot anticipate. In a recent interview with AFP last month, the commander of the SDF forces said, “In 2019 we had an unsuccessful experience with the Trump administration, but we are confident that the United States makes its decisions based on strategic interest in the region.”

At one point, all of this must be discussed. Since 2020, Syria has been in the shadows of everything. The world will have to deal with this question: For how long can Syria be this tattered country?

Everyone is involved in the answer—the U.S., Turkey, Russia, Iran. At one point, something must be decided. The Kurds are afraid that they will have to pay the price. After all their sacrifice fighting the Islamic State group, they don’t want to lose.

In February, you moved to Iraq to become AFP’s Deputy Bureau Chief in Baghdad. How do you plan on navigating the transition from being on the front lines to a managing role?

How can I describe Baghdad? I mean, Baghdad is a frontline by itself. It’s a city of civilization, but also chaos and exhaustion. Iraqis have endured so much for decades, before and after the 2003 invasion. They’re still trying to recover, and this is coming so slowly.

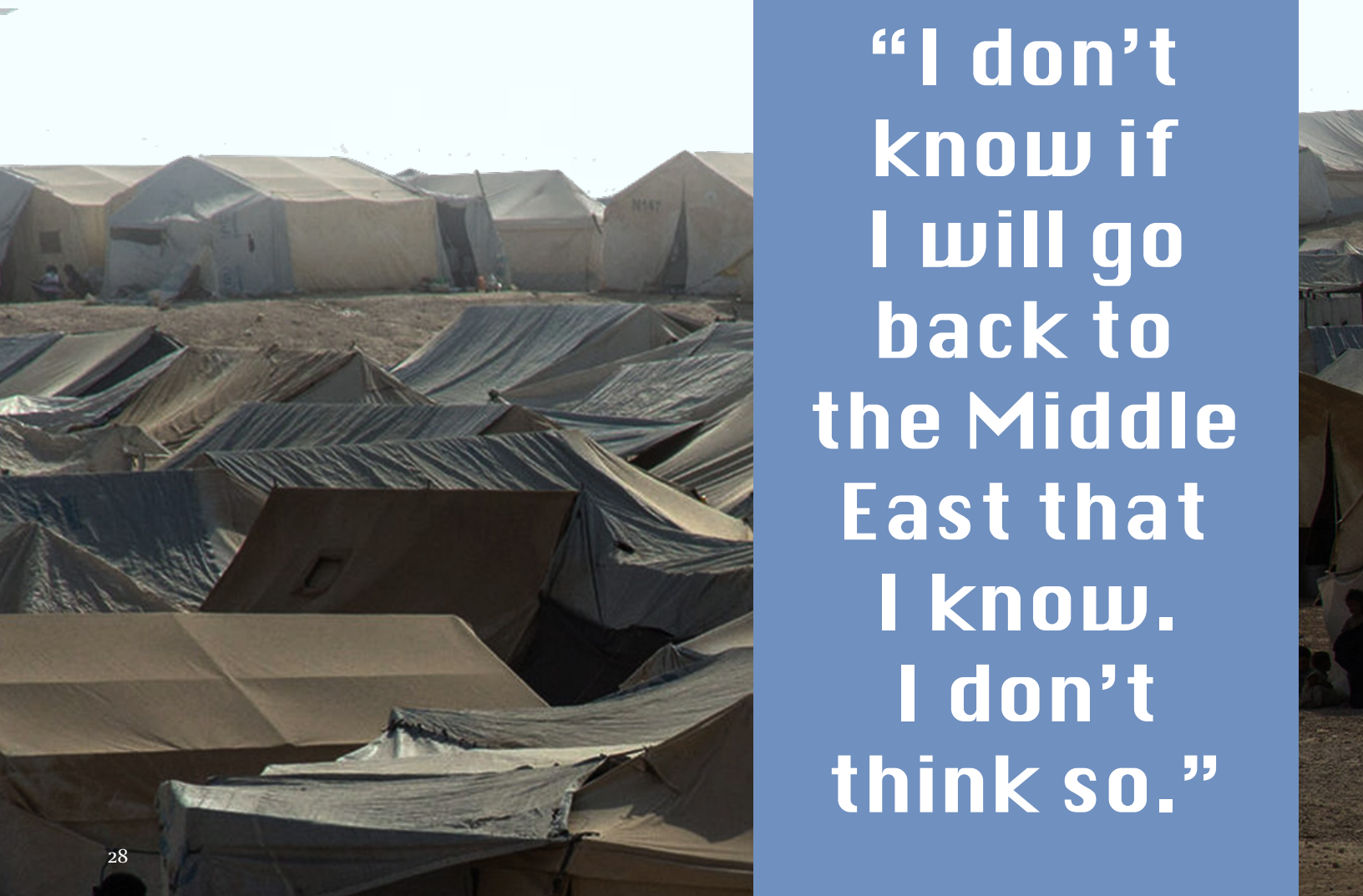
In the Middle East, countries are intertwined together. I wouldn’t have done a good job covering Syria if I hadn’t understood Iraqi politics or history. Whatever happens in Palestine, you feel it in Lebanon. The war starts in Syria, and we feel it in Lebanon. When you want to cover one country in the Middle East, you must understand the whole region’s politics.

I’ve always been an on-the-ground person. Being in Baghdad and doing management at the same time has been challenging—not altogether new but challenging.

Iraq is a very rich country. Imagine how many stories are there, how many stories people want to tell. Climate change in Iraq is the big thing. You see it, it’s so clear, the pollution, climate displacement, how the Euphrates and the Tigris are fading.

There’s always a story in Iraq and unfortunately, it is not on the front pages anymore, like Syria, like so many forgotten conflicts and countries in this world. I mean, look at Sudan, there are 11 million displaced, tens of thousands killed every day.

How do you prepare for the challenges of reporting in conflict zones, both during the assignment and in coping with the aftermath?



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It's not something that should be normalized."

It's not only the frontline, it's the daily job. Working for a news agency like AFP, you work around the clock. When covering the Syria conflict, some days we worked 15 hours straight. You get exhausted.

On the front line, physical safety comes first but you need mental health to overcome what you're seeing in the moment and to do the reporting job. Then, you deal with the aftermath. You need a support system. I get it from my colleagues and my friends. That's a priority for every journalist, on the frontline or not.

How does being a female journalist in conflict zones shape your experiences compared to your male counterparts? What advice would you give to young women interested in conflict journalism?

Do it! I mean, it's challenging for us women everywhere. You are on the front line, and you have someone telling you, "Maybe not you, maybe him." But why not me? Why him? These kinds of challenges hit you all the time. You just have to prove yourself and be the best journalist you can be.

It must indeed be incredibly tough seeing present events in the region from here.

What's happening now is changing everything, it's reshaping the Middle East. I don't know if I will go back to the Middle East that I know. I don't think so.

I went crazy for the first two weeks when the war started in Lebanon. I was already going crazy because of everything happening there and in Gaza. I mean, I wake up every morning to check if my friends in Gaza have sent me a message, to make sure they are okay.

Journalists or not, war is never something that people should get used to. We cover war, but every front line, battlefield, and camp is different, the people are different, and the stories are different. It hits you in the face every time there's war. It's not something that should be normalized. Even though I grew up in a place like Lebanon and the Middle East where people would say, "These people are used to wars", we don't want to be used to wars.

How can you detach yourself from all the suffering around you? How can you detach yourself from your own country? It's impossible.

Photo Credit: Yan Boechat, Voice of America